benefits through constrained international bargaining and restrict the ability of weaker powers to improve their positions and change existing policies. Thus, the daily operations of institutions will tend to generate outcomes that replicate the status quo.[81] This is the epitome of structural power, where the preponderant actors formalize their preferences into legal regimes and in so doing constrain or close off other weaker actors' choices.[82] Lloyd Gruber aptly calls this process "ruling the world."[83] Former President Barack Obama provides evidence for this argument, noting that "it was America that largely built a system of international institutions that carried us through the Cold War … . Instead of constraining our power, these institutions magnified it."[84]

How have emerging powers replicated this club mechanism, and can they avoid becoming irrelevant "talking shops"? Although club theory does not specify a particular distribution of power among members, the assumption of relative equality is not required. Clubs may feature asymmetrical power relationships and even "club within the club" dynamics when one or more members possess greater power resources or membership in other possibly more exclusive groups. States may engage in what political scientists term "forum shopping" to gain clout to push their positions and prevent opposing coalitions from winning.[85] This chapter returns to these characteristics next, in the context of China's position within the BRICS and its structural similarity to the U.S. dominance within the G7.

Two governance-related concepts of clubs are relevant to understanding BRICS collaboration. The first focuses on how major international institutions operate more effectively when they employ the club model. The second examines ways that the leading powers have refined their operationalization of the club model to work in concert and benefit themselves.

The first aspect of the club model, introduced by Robert Keohane and Joseph Nye, shows its benefits as an effective institutional mechanism. With respect to public goods, Keohane and Nye argue that the club model of governance regimes paradoxically helps to "overcome deadlock that accompanies the diffusion of power"[86] and achieve more effective outcomes because it involves transgovernmental networks of specialized elite players operating in nontransparent back rooms. These networks of senior officials can break logjams and forge bargains conducive to their